

Lesson 6

The Recalibration Phase - Navigating the Hard Part

Once I stopped reacting and started responding, I expected some kind of relief. 'cause I thought, okay, I'm finally doing the right thing. I'm doing the thing everyone tells me to do, so surely I'm gonna feel better soon. But instead, what happened was my fear got louder, my symptoms felt a lot more noticeable, and my mind got more aggressive.

It like I was wondering, have I made a mistake here? Because that urge to start looking around for the next shiny solution was very, very strong. And this is the moment I think most people panic. This is where people abandoned the approach and go back to reacting and trying to solve. And what I wish I had known was that this phase is very normal.

It's also temporary, and it means that what you're doing is actually working because when you stop feeding your fear. With your reactions, your nervous system is not gonna immediately calm down. It's gonna test you a little bit. It's gonna throw up some louder sensations, some scarier thoughts, and some terrifying.

What if scenarios for you to work through? But I need you to understand that nothing is going wrong when this happens. The pattern just isn't being reinforced in the same way anymore. So your system is gonna push a little bit harder to see, does the old way still work? It's like it's asking, are you sure about this?

Are you really not gonna react this time? I know that when sensations or symptoms escalate, it feels very dangerous, but it's not dangerous. It's a sign that the system is recalibrating and desensitizing. It's adjusting to the new way of responding that you're engaging in, and that adjustment is gonna be uncomfortable.

But like I said, it's actually a good sign because we're doing what we wanna do, which is interrupting the pattern. One of the most surprising parts for me was my mind got. Aggressive. It got urgent and it got very persuasive. There were lots of thoughts like, this is not working. You are ignoring something very important because what if this time it's really different?

You need to check. You need to just get back into that Facebook group, try to see if anyone else has gone through this. You're being irresponsible. We're going down the wrong path. And so before, when I would react to those things with what it was suggesting, like researching or checking or reassurance, my, my nervous system would quiet.

Those thoughts would calm down, but when I stopped doing that, they got louder. Obviously, they were not getting what they were used to getting. Your thoughts are not true just because they are loud. I don't care if they are screaming at you. They are screaming because you stopped soothing them. What you were doing was temporary and it was a bandaid and it didn't work.

That's why it kept coming back. That's why it wasn't getting better. So because you've changed into a good response, they're just ramping up. That is normal. What about when your symptoms shift? I wish someone had explicitly told me this, symptoms are often going to shift rather than disappear. For me, in my experience, my physical symptoms would calm down and then mental symptoms would go up, and then the reverse would happen, and then something completely new would pop up.

It felt like, all right, so now this is the problem. Great. Now my brain is doing this instead, but looking back on it and fully understanding it now, it wasn't new danger. It wasn't new symptoms, it wasn't a new diagnosis. It was the same sensitized system just expressing itself in a different way. So the form may have been changing, but the underlying pattern was the same.

So if your symptoms are moving around, if they are swapping places, if you're getting new ones, if physical ones are calming down, mental ones are going up or reverse, that is part of the process. It's just the system shifting, nothing's breaking, and as haywire as it may look from the outside, this is normal.

And to be expected. If it doesn't happen, congratulations. 'cause you're one of the lucky ones. This phase of recalibration is gonna feel like regression. It's gonna maybe look and feel like you are actually worse than before, like you messed something up. And that's what's gonna drive this feeling of wanting to go back to what you were doing because that was giving you some relief.

But what's actually happening is you removed your escape path and your system has not learned that it is safe. Yet. So it's putting up a fight. It's protesting, it's trying to protect you. Ultimately, at the end of the day, as annoying and as obnoxious as it's progress in this phase is not gonna look like feeling better.

It's going to be, you notice you're responding differently even when you feel the same or worse. There is a phase when you're going through this, of there being nothing to do. And this phase was very hard for me because I couldn't really fix it. I couldn't escape it. I couldn't reassure myself out of it, and I couldn't research my way through it.

There was, there was nothing I could do to make it stop without going back to the old things that I knew were signaling danger. All I could do was feel it, not react and keep on living, and that felt like I wasn't doing anything. It felt like I had too much spare time, but what I was actually doing was very specific.

I was letting my nervous system know and learn that the discomfort that we were feeling could be there without me doing anything about. Often people will ask, how long does this phase last? And the truth is that you may have various stages of this specific phase as you are recovering from

sensitization.

But I do wanna be honest with you about something because it may look this way for you and it may not. But I felt. Pretty terrible implementing all of this for about four months. It was four months of responding differently, practicing acceptance, and allowing, which of course I'm gonna talk about in the next couple of lessons, four months of feeling.

Horrible feeling like I was in this, fake it till I make it mode and wondering if any of this was actually working because I didn't have signs that it was in the form that I wanted, which is do I feel better? Are my symptoms gone? Like it's so challenging to keep your head in the game when you are in a recalibration phase.

But during those four months, there were days where I did feel like I was making progress, and then there were also days where I was convinced I had messed everything up, and there were stretches where symptoms were quieter, and I would think, oh, I think I'm making some progress here. I think I'm turning a corner.

And then everything would just flare up again. There were moments where I wanted to stop. There were moments where I was crying in my car in a. Park parking lot. There were moments where I just wanted to go back to what was helping me to feel safe so that I could feel like I had a little bit of control, but I didn't give up because I had already committed to going all in on this.

I was not gonna say it didn't work unless I had given it a really, really good effort, thorough a hundred percent of what I had to give. So I kept responding. In the way that I needed to respond, even when it felt pointless because it wasn't quote unquote doing anything. And then something shifted around month four.

It's like I started seeing everything was clicking into place, and I'll be honest with you, my anxiety was gone. My insomnia was gone and all of my symptoms began improving. I'm not telling you this to expect four months because your timeline might be shorter. It might be way longer, but I want you to know that this phase isn't a week.

Like it's not a quick reset here, and if you're in it for a while, it doesn't mean it's not working because like I told you, this process is gonna take most likely between one and three to four years. But you can make immense amounts of progress in six to 12 months where you are feeling like a brand, a new person, and then we work from there and everything's a lot easier.

At that point, there were subtle signs that I wish I had paid attention to a bit sooner. I think I really only saw them looking backward, but I noticed that my episodes, my flares, my setbacks, whatever you wanna call them. They didn't escalate the same way that they had for so long. Something would trigger me or trigger my symptoms and I just wasn't spiraling for hours.

I would notice that symptoms and panic and anxiety and stuff would, it would pass in like 20 minutes. I was recovering faster and faster from being triggered. I started spending way less time thinking

about my symptoms, like even if they were there, they weren't the first thing I thought about in the morning, which felt like a miracle.

They weren't the last thing I thought about at the end of the day. I just noticed life was happening more. I was doing things, I was going places, I was having conversations, and my symptoms weren't the main focus anymore. They just were able to kind of move to side stage or move to the background, and my fear was just down like 75%.

It was not running my decisions or my schedule wasn't. Canceling things. I wasn't avoiding things and I wasn't like determining what am I gonna do today based on how I felt. I was doing what I wanted to do, regardless of how I felt. And there was something about not. Having that pressure of needing to fix everything or find an answer that provided so much mental relief, I was still bringing in things that made me happy.

So even though I felt really terrible, it wasn't as heavy as it could have been, and it wasn't as heavy as it was for so long. I was so much less afraid of being uncomfortable, and that was a really true shift for me. So I'll say it again, when discomfort spikes. You are going to have a tendency to assume that something is wrong.

You are going to think, even when you have a very intense spike in symptoms, you're going to feel like you're going backwards and you're going to get pulled into old patterns. You're gonna stop what you're doing and you're gonna go try something else. Please notice when that happens and bring yourself back to center.

This is not going to get fixed with piling more techniques and tools on top. Those aren't gonna work. They haven't worked up until this point. They're gonna work better for you a little bit further down the line. We wanna do our best not to keep resetting this cycle. And I think most people just don't understand like what this phase actually looks like.

So they just assume the worst immediately, which makes sense because that stressed part of your survival brain is what is running the show most of the time. But you can't keep abandoning what you're doing thinking that there's some other thing out there that's gonna help you, especially because what I found is a lot of the time people do that, right, when everything is starting to work and starting to click into place.

So what I want you to know is if you're in this phase right now. It feels worse because you stopped feeding it. Okay? Nothing is wrong. You don't need to now fix what's happening. You're not missing anything. You don't need clarity on anything. There's nothing confusing or special or mysterious that I'm keeping from you.

You are not in danger. Your brain is gonna wanna think. There's something she didn't tell me. I need her to clarify what do I do exactly in this situation? And I'm gonna tell you again, that is your brain. Grasping for control and certainty. That's part of sensitization. That's part of this whole deal.

There's no clarity that's gonna let you escape what you're feeling right now. We need to feel it to move through it. You need to do this not forever, but long enough for your system to learn a new normal. And it's gonna require the hard days to get better. I wanna take a minute to tell you what's on the other side of this, because when you are in the thick of it, when you are feeling hopeless, when you are in a setback, it is very hard to imagine things.

Being any different than they are right now. I had moments of deep, deep darkness where I was convinced that nothing could help me and that I was a uniquely broken case. What I have found that is not unique about that is that we all feel it. We all think there is something special and uniquely broken about us, and it has something to do with our past or how we were raised, or how long it's been or how severe or whatever.

That's one of the most common things about sensitization. Okay, but things can change for you in a really real way. My chronic anxiety is gone, not managed, not under control. Gone. I do not wake up with that sick feeling in my stomach anymore and that racing heart. I don't spend my days mentally checking in with my body and waiting for the other shoe to drop like I've done for the previous 20 years.

My insomnia is gone. I sleep eight and a half hours at night. I sleep through the night. I don't wake up in the middle of the night running through worst case scenarios, and that was reality for so long. My health OCD. Every, every aspect of that this need to know for certain is completely gone. I'm traveling, I'm taking trips again, that would've been unthinkable.

I'm able to be present for real life stressors like my daughter having surgery. I still have some physical symptoms, but that's just part of the desensitizing process. You know, my body is catching up. They're very infrequent. More often than not, my symptoms are gone. I'm not organizing my days around how I feel.

I make plans and I keep them. If I have hard days, I recover from them quickly and I finally feel like myself again. I feel better than myself. I've met a version of myself I didn't even know, and that's what we're building toward here. That's what's available for you. It's not some perfect like zen state where nothing ever bothers you and nothing ever gets to you and you never get upset.

It's a life that isn't run by fear, and when the fear. Goes the symptoms. Follow it. You have the ability to build a life and you're in the middle of it right now, listening to my voice, where you are actually present for the people and the things that you really care about, and that's what's available to you on the other side of this phase.

And I wanna speak to it. I want you to know that that is what is coming for you. That is what we're building tort. And once this phase passes and things start to ease for you the urgency. Quiets down and that internal pressure lets up and acceptance starts to feel possible instead of terrifying. And allowing your sensations stops feeling like such a big threat and risk.

You can't skip this part, but you can get through it. And what's waiting on the other side is worth it. So in the next lesson, I wanna talk all about acceptance, what it is, what it isn't, and why it matters so much for this work.